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Portfolio Snapshots Compilation

March 2025

Blue Meridian is dedicated to increasing economic mobility in the US and maintains diverse investment portfolios that address the problems trapping young people and families in poverty.

Meeting Scale with Scale

solutions at scale through investments at scale

Nationwide Solutions

blue meridian partners

Bringing evidence-based solutions to national scale

Portfolio Overview

Nationwide Solutions provides growth capital to scale strategies that **improve economic and social mobility and embed effective practices in systems** for sustained change. **We do this in service of Blue Meridian's mission** to transform the life trajectories of young people and families in poverty.

Nearly **$1.6B** committed to date

The Problem

We know solutions exist, but even the most promising **strategies cannot reach far enough, fast enough without significant, long-term investments.** Yet, philanthropy's prevailing model prioritizes small-dollar grants, hindering leaders' ability to think bigger and act boldly to pursue national growth. To meet the scale of the problems that leaders seek to address, they need large, unrestricted capital to enable growth.

Our Approach

We make significant, long-term investments to address the causes and drivers of poverty by bringing **evidence-based** solutions to national scale. These **strategic, long-term** investments of $100 million or more in a single initiative allow organizations to plan for the long term and accelerate efforts to scale their reach, influence, and impact nationwide. We know there is no silver bullet or single approach to solve the problems that limit economic mobility, so we invest in a variety of domains such as **early childhood development, workforce, access to post-secondary education, and family planning, among others**. In addition to financial resources, we provide our investees with strategic counsel, **including collaborating on their scaling plans** and identifying milestones to measure success.

The Nationwide Solutions portfolio encompasses some of Blue Meridian Partners' biggest opportunities for significant change — a core portfolio where we make investments that are right-sized to the scale of the problems we seek to address. **The lessons learned through this work will continue to inform Blue Meridian's evolving approach.**

Nationwide Solutions portfolio uses seven selection criteria to vet both current and future investees:

- **Strong Leadership**
- **Compelling Vision**
- **Track Record of Growth**
- **Evidence of Effectiveness**
- **Pathway to Scale**
- **Sustainable Economic Model**
- **Racial Equity**

Nationwide Solutions

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Problem: Children who experience foster care are at much greater risk of negative life outcomes, including criminal justice system involvement, teen pregnancy, and job instability. The stakes are even higher for young adults who age out of the system.

Solution: Help 135k children and older youth at risk of entering, re-entering, and aging out of foster care stay with their families safely, and support 25k older youth to successfully transition to adulthood by making evidence-based programs, like **Youth Villages' Intercept and LifeSet** available nationally.

Problem: There are 2.2 million families living in federally-subsidized housing. Accumulating assets is one of the strongest predictors of potential to break multi-generational poverty. However, the opportunity to do so is out of reach due to penalties that discourage accumulated savings, perpetuating a persistent wealth gap.

Solution: **Compass Working Capital** is leveraging the Department of Housing and Urban Development's Family Self-Sufficiency Program to help more than 15,000 families with low incomes increase their earned income and build assets and financial capability.

Problem: In the US, approximately 76 million working adults are unemployed or working low-wage jobs - many living in or near-poverty conditions with limited access to higher-wage employment. Jobs with high earning potential can be obtained through workforce training; however, lack of capital, resources, and networks are barriers, particularly for Black and/or Latinx adults.

Solution: Occupations in the tech industry are projected to grow faster than the overall workforce and have high earning potential. **Per Scholas** is the largest provider of evidence-based workforce training for unemployed and low-wage workers - providing participants with the hands-on technical skills, professional development, and networking opportunities needed to advance their careers and earn higher wages to gain economic mobility.employer demand.

Problem: Billions of dollars in government safety net programs remain unclaimed every year by people who are eligible. Applications for programs like SNAP, WIC and Medicaid tend to follow outdated, disjointed, and complicated processes that require immense effort for already distressed populations.

Solution: **Code for America**'s Safety Net Innovation Lab works to unlock an estimated $30 billion in benefits to reach as many as 13 million individuals. The program will remove key barriers to accessing government benefits across 15 states.

Problem: An estimated 11 million low-income women in the US face barriers to mainstream financial services and a lack of working capital that inhibit their ability to launch, sustain, and grow successful businesses that could enable them to achieve financial stability.

Solution: **Grameen America's** high-touch, trust-based microlending model provides affordable working capital; coupled with credit-building supports, free savings account, financial education, and peer support to low-income entrepreneurial woman, most affected by financial exclusion to help them build and grow small businesses and access a path to greater economic mobility for 750k women entrepreneurs by 2033.

Problem: Few low-income families have access to effective early childhood supports, despite overwhelming evidence linking early emotional and cognitive development to school and life success.

Solution: Transform the delivery and funding of pediatric primary care — accessed by 90% of all families — to drive better developmental outcomes for young children by expanding the **HealthySteps** model of in-office specialist support.

Nationwide Solutions

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Problem: Nearly three million pregnancies in the US are unplanned every year. Unplanned pregnancies are associated with adverse birth outcomes, and disruption of educational attainment and workforce participation. Low-income women experience unplanned pregnancies 5x more than wealthier women, perpetuating intergenerational poverty.

Solution: **Upstream USA** seeks to improve equitable access to the highest-quality contraceptive care for all women by training health clinics to offer single-visit access to a full range of safe, effective contraceptives.

Problem: Roughly 50 million Americans work low-wage jobs, with only 43% gaining a pathway out of those jobs within 10 years. While college remains the an important pathway to economic mobility - it is still out of reach for many who are in poverty - and an alternative pathway out of low-wage work to gain the skills and career search support isn't accessible in the U.S.

Solution: **Merit America** provides a new pathway leading low-wage workers to higher-wage jobs and careers, pairing individuals with in-demand, entry-level positions with upward mobility. Their educational programs to teach tech or IT professional skills needed to maintain and excel in jobs earned through Merit America's employer partnerships.

Problem: HBCUs increase economic mobility for low-income, first generation students. However, they face a lack of capacity and funding, threatening their financial sustainability and their ability to serve the needs of current and future students.

Solution: The **HBCU Transformation Project** invests in three intermediaries to support the highest performing and highest potential HBCUs. It builds capacity to increase enrollment and student outcomes, and supports HBCUs long-term sustainability, in service of increasing economic mobility and wealth for communities.

Problem: Two-thirds of jobs in the US require a post-secondary credential, yet only one-third of students from low-income families have post-secondary credentials within eight years of graduating high school. While accelerated training models provide training for in-demand jobs, individuals are often unable to access them due to tuition costs.

Solution: Career Impact Bonds (CIBs) are a student-friendly financing model to unlock access to high-quality workforce training providers. Social Finance's Up Fund and Pay-it-Forward Funds use impact investing capital, philanthropy, and public funding to provide the capital needed to structure and finance CIBs.

Problem: Centuries of economic exclusion in America have left 100 million people struggling to make ends meet. This has also prevented generations of families and children from realizing their potential. Achieving equity at scale demands transforming the systems and institutions that prevent policies focused on economic opportunity from unleashing their full impact.

Solution: **PolicyLink**'s "A Nation that Works for All" strategy seeks to advance policy changes and unlock public resources, including place-based infrastructure, to benefit the greatest public good. The goal of this long-term strategy is to enable all people in the United States to participate in a flourishing democracy, benefit from an equitable economy, and prosper in thriving communities of opportunity.

Problem: Approximately 50,000 youth in fostercare who face the greatest obstacles to finding permanent homes are ages nine or older, have special needs, and/or are part of a sibling group.

Solution: Find adoptive families for the hardest-to-place kids by making the most effective approach — **Wendy's Wonderful Kids'** child-focused recruitment model — standard practice nationally.

Place Matters

blue meridian partners

Strengthening communities through place-based partnerships & catalytic supports

Portfolio Overview

Blue Meridian's Place Matters portfolio aims to **improve the economic and social mobility of young people and families** in communities across the US. We believe in the power of communities to come together across sectors, identify shared goals, and create interventions specific to their needs. Through a comprehensive strategy, the portfolio invests in both **place-based partnerships** — a community-driven, outcomes-focused approach — and the necessary **ecosystem of supports to catalyze the success** of each partnership.

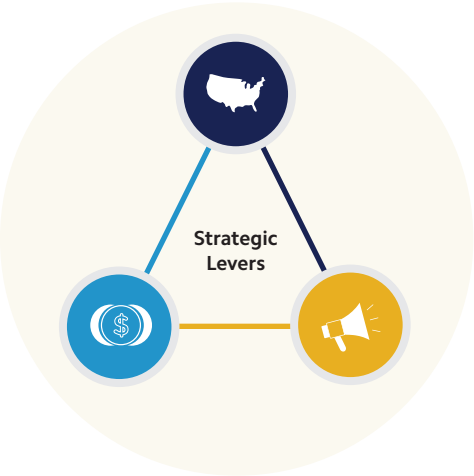
The Problem

Research has consistently shown that **a person's geography all too often determines their destiny**. An individual's local community and living environment dictate the resources and opportunities they will have throughout their life. At the same time, the devastating effects of inequity in underserved communities have prevented many people from accessing opportunity and achieving their full potential. In light of this, improving economic and social mobility require **coordinated interventions tailored to the unique needs of each community**. Even when social sector leaders are responsive to the needs of local people, their **success is often limited by a lack of access to funding and supports.**

Our Approach

The Place Matters portfolio builds on **Blue Meridian's multi-year investment in and learnings** from Tulsa, Oklahoma, and Guilford County, NC, alongside our regional and neighborhood partners and past place-based efforts. The portfolio is core to Blue Meridian's overall investing strategy and reflects our belief that place-based work is a powerful avenue for improving the life trajectories of young people and families in poverty. Ultimately, we aim to leave communities in control of shaping their own destinies and **amplifying the array of solutions they can scale** to achieve lasting impact.

Our Strategy



Invest in Existing Place-Based Partnerships

Place-based partnerships are a community-driven, outcomes-focused approach to designing and implementing solutions that are tailored to local needs. Guided by shared principles, they create cradle-to-career opportunity pathways. Through Place Matters, Blue Meridian is making large-scale investments in regional and neighborhood place-based partnerships in order to accelerate the ability of these partnerships to achieve positive outcomes at the population level.

Increase Nationwide Availability of Catalytic Supports

To cultivate the ecosystem necessary for place-based partnerships to move more quickly and succeed at scale, we are investing in national intermediaries to increase availability of effective tools and resources. This will enable leaders to better track results and hone their efforts over time to achieve transformational and sustained outcomes. We are also investing in policy change to sustain and scale these supports.

Unlock Private and Public Capital

We seek to leverage Blue Meridian's national capital to spur regional capital aggregation and unlock other funding streams. Significant investment from public and private sources to evidence-informed strategies is required in order to accelerate an equitable recovery and to achieve sustained results.

Place Matters

blue meridian partners

Our Investments

Nearly $590 committed

25 total investments

9 key catalytic supports

Places

Key Catalytic Supports

William Julius Wilson Institute — At Harlem Children's Zone
Purpose Built Communities
GARE
Code for America
catalyst:ed
Haywood Burns Institute — Justice. Fairness. Equity.
Results for America
StriveTogether — Every child. Cradle to career.
Harvard Kennedy School Government Performance Lab
Partners for Rural Impact

Our Partners

The Place Matters portfolio draws upon the philanthropic capital pooled by all of Blue Meridian's Partners as well as anchor funding from General Partner Ballmer Group. With a shared vision to leverage the power of place to increase access to opportunity in the US, Ballmer Group provided insight and collaboration on key aspects of the investing strategy.

ballmer GROUP

The Studio @ Blue Meridian

blue meridian partners

Accelerating organizations' readiness for scale

Portfolio Overview

The Studio @ Blue Meridian supports social sector organizations and leaders to accelerate their readiness to significantly scale their reach, impact, and influence. These investments **seek to empower visionary leaders who are ready to think big and prepare for transformational growth** by providing access to the flexible resources — both coaching and capital — required to test and enhance their approach to solving intractable and emerging social challenges.

The Problem

Promising solutions to problems that trap young people and families in poverty do exist, but the visionary leaders advancing these solutions often face barriers on their path to tackling the magnitude of the problem. Additionally, there are **two critical gaps in the social sector capital market** that hinder organizations from addressing these challenges: lack of flexible resources available to leaders with proven track records looking to experiment and iterate upon their existing platforms, and lack of funding flowing to leaders of color.

Over
$406M
in commitments
to date

Our Approach

The Studio @ Blue Meridian was created to help fill these gaps by investing in social sector organizations in order to accelerate their readiness to significantly scale their reach, impact, and influence.

These investments provide visionary leaders who have had limited access to social sector capital, with the **flexible funding and tailored advisory support they need to think big and to test and refine their approach** to solving persistent or emerging social challenges.

The Studio is a central pillar of Blue Meridian Partners' commitment to collaboration and experimentation in our effort to cast a wider net in search of innovative ideas and leaders.

Looking Ahead

Blue Meridian looks forward to the evolution and expansion of The Studio @ Blue Meridian in the future. As we continue to embrace innovation, we are committed to funding organizations with diverse leadership teams and meeting arising needs — including expediting an equitable recovery from the COVID-19 pandemic — in support of economic opportunity for all.

Investments

Through its investment in the implementation of two- to three-year action plans, The Studio @ Blue Meridian supports organizations' work to overcome a range of barriers to scale, from building evidence to testing new pathways to reaching more beneficiaries and beyond. To date, The Studio has committed over $410M since its inception in 2019.

The Studio @ Blue Meridian is currently supporting 13 exemplary organizations preparing for future transformative scaling.

Centering Healthcare Institute

bellxcel

CODEPATH.ORG

Power to Decide

Communities In Schools

mdrc — Building Knowledge to Improve Social Policy

nichq — National Institute for Children's Health Quality

Equal Opportunity Schools

TRAILS

OneGoal

Youth Guidance — Guiding Kids to Bright Futures

saga Education

"We came into the process with a set of sound hypotheses… but the methodology and intense probing and support getting to the final Action Plan would have never happened without [The Studio]."

"Once you say, 'Think big,' and then, 'Think bigger,' it's inspiring. And for somebody to have a funder [support] that kind of thinking and ambition, that's important to us."

"This clear, concrete framework for how to iterate, and then ultimately innovate…has had one of the biggest impacts on us."

-Selected quotes from leaders of participating organizations

The Justice and Mobility Fund

blue meridian partners

Creating economic opportunity for people and communities impacted by the justice system

Portfolio Overview

The Justice and Mobility Fund is a philanthropic collaboration that aims to boost economic mobility and improve the life trajectories of people impacted by the criminal justice system. Reducing convictions and incarceration — and mitigating their negative downstream effects — is critical to giving people greater access to jobs, educational opportunities, and housing that will help break the cycle of poverty and inequality.

The Problem

77M

Americans have criminal records and millions more interact with the justice system each year

Mass criminalization and incarceration is one of the most critical issues of our time, one that severely impacts economic stability and access to opportunity for individuals, families, and whole communities. Engagement with the system hinders people's ability to get an education, maintain stable housing, and connect to and qualify for employment opportunities and access to public benefits, among many other challenges, affecting families for generations. Despite justice reform efforts, **insufficient attention is paid to developing and scaling interventions that provide pathways to economic mobility for people impacted by the justice system.**

Our Approach

The Justice and Mobility Fund makes large, flexible investments in nationally scalable solutions as well as strategic place-based investments designed to empower social sector leaders to extend their reach, influence, and impact. These leaders work across the spectrum of the justice system to reduce the harm caused by system involvement with a particular focus on building pathways to employment and economic opportunity.

We will invest approximately $400 million through the Justice and Mobility Fund. To date, we have committed over $310M to solutions that build the infrastructure for justice reforms which foster upward economic mobility and to COVID-19 emergency relief.

Over $310M committed to date

The Collaboration

The Justice and Mobility Fund is a collaboration launched by Blue Meridian Partners, the Ford Foundation, and Charles and Lynn Schusterman Family Philanthropies.

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FORD FOUNDATION

CHARLES AND LYNN SCHUSTERMAN FAMILY PHILANTHROPIES

The Justice and Mobility Fund

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Investing Strategy

The Justice and Mobility Fund invests in strategies working to safely mitigate the impact of criminal convictions and incarceration, as well as in solutions supporting low-income people and families most affected by the justice system.

Our Priorities

- There is no single solution that will achieve the progress we aim to see; rather, the Justice and Mobility Fund invests in complementary solutions at key touchpoints across the justice system that span direct service provision, policy advocacy, changing the narrative on criminal justice reform, and building the evidence base for what works.
- We make nationwide and state-specific investments, supporting interventions that reduce barriers and foster economic opportunity and stability.
- We are deploying a comprehensive employment strategy to help people with a criminal record overcome barriers to employment and employers adopt policies and practices conducive to hiring and advancing people with criminal records. These investments promote Fair Chance Hiring and create pathways to living wages for people with criminal records.

PORTFOLIO OF **NATIONWIDE** REFORM ORGANIZATIONS

INVESTMENTS IN **STATES/JURISDICTIONS** POISED FOR REFORM

SCALE READINESS INVESTMENTS | **PROJECT INVESTMENTS**

Our Investments

The Justice and Mobility Fund has committed over $310 million to build the infrastructure of leading organizations that are advancing reforms and innovations that boost economic mobility for people impacted by the justice system.

NATIONWIDE INVESTMENTS

- JFF
- Center for Employment Opportunities
- Vera Institute of Justice
- Clean Slate
- Alliance for Safety and Justice

SCALE READINESS INVESTMENTS

- National Employment Law Project
- Center for Policing Equity
- REDF

EMPLOYMENT COHORT

- Fortune Society
- ARC
- OIC of America
- A New Way of Life
- Rubicon Programs
- STRIVE

PROJECT INVESTMENTS

- JLUSA
- REFORM
- Responsible Business Initiative for Justice

PLACE-BASED INVESTMENTS

- Michigan
- Louisiana
- Oklahoma

blue meridian partners | Ford Foundation | Charles and Lynn Schusterman Family Philanthropies

COVID-19 Response

blue meridian partners

Supporting children and families disproportionately affected by COVID-19

Over
$260M
in commitments to date

COVID-19 has caused immense, disproportionate harm **to vulnerable people throughout the US**. Blue Meridian's COVID-19 Response portfolio provides funding to organizations serving the hardest-hit communities.

$110M+ in Education Recovery

In 2021, Blue Meridian began investing in organizations that will bring urgently needed capital and technical assistance to education leaders, supporting the children and families disproportionately affected by the pandemic as they **prepare for and re-engage with school**.

The COVID-19 crisis has profoundly disrupted the education system, disconnecting millions of students from school with months of learning left unfinished. Against this backdrop, the federal government deployed unprecedented resources into school districts nationwide.

Our Education Recovery investments provide the upfront and timely capital needed to **maximize the impact of federal resources on student success and well-being** and to lay the groundwork for future systemic improvement and innovation.

$150M+ in Emergency Relief

As part of our immediate response to the pandemic at its outset in the spring of 2020, Blue Meridian committed more than **$150 million for COVID-19 emergency relief to help low-income people** who were at the greatest risk of falling through the cracks, providing essential support to individuals and families experiencing acute economic distress as a result of the pandemic — from job loss to lack of affordable housing.

Blue Meridian supported social sector organizations that provide cash assistance to individuals and families in need of immediate financial assistance as well as help millions more access public benefits for which they were eligible.

Beyond the emergency relief funding, we were also dedicated to **supporting our existing investees** to help them weather the crisis and, when ready, accelerate work to meet the growing needs that emerged from the pandemic.

Our Adapted Investment Approach

Our philanthropic model is built so that we are able to **respond nimbly in support of an equitable recovery**. This adapted investment approach ensures that the most marginalized communities — those that suffer disproportionately due to historic and system inequity — receive support towards an ongoing and equitable recovery that boosts economic mobility for individuals and families trapped in poverty.

Investments

Education Recovery

Our Education Recovery investments happen in two ways: scaling high-quality interventions to accelerate reach and impact; and supporting states and districts in implementing initiatives that advance student outcomes. To date, we have invested in 21 organizations:

- BellXcel
- Build Initiative
- Chiefs for Change
- Common App
- Communities In Schools
- Council of Chief State School Officers
- EducationSuperHighway
- First Nations Development Institute
- The Hunt Institute
- MDRC SUCCESS
- New Profit
- NewSchools Venture Fund
- OneGoal
- Ready4K
- Saga Education
- Springboard Collaborative
- Share Our Strength
- Start Early
- TalkingPoints
- TRAILS
- Zearn

Emergency Relief

Our past Emergency Relief commitments were allocated to 22 organizations throughout 2020:

- Beeck Center for Social Impact + Innovation
- Benefits Data Trust
- BET/ United Way
- Center on Budget and Policy Priorities
- Center for Employment Opportunities (CEO): Returning Citizen Stimulus
- Code for America
- UpTogether
- The Education Trust
- Food Research & Action Center
- GiveDirectly
- Hispanics in Philanthropy: Essential Workers' Fund and Farmworkers' Relief Fund
- Mission Asset Fund
- National Domestic Workers Alliance
- National Employment Law Project
- Native American Community Response Fund
- New America
- No Kid Hungry
- One Fair Wage
- Prosperity Now
- United Way/211
- The Workers Lab
- Working America

Learn more *about our Emergency Relief and Education Recovery Investments.*

Funding for Blue Meridian's COVID-19 Response was contributed by all our General and Impact Partners, with additional support for our Emergency Relief investments provided by The David Tepper Family Foundation; The Druckenmiller Foundation; The Duke Endowment; George Kaiser Family Foundation; The JPB Foundation; MacKenzie Scott; Charles and Lynn Schusterman Family Philanthropies; and others.